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SHUBHANSHU SHUKLA 40
Spacefarer

Star Trekker

Becoming only the second Indian after Rakesh Sharma to transcend Earth's boundaries and reach space, Shubhanshu Shukla marked an important milestone in India's space mission

By AJAY SUKUMARAN

Legions of wide-eyed kids sat glued to their living room TVs in 1984 as Punjab boy Rakesh Sharma made a call to Indian prime minister Indira Gandhi from space and, training his gaze on the nation, said it was "*Saare jahan se accha*" (the best of them all). Though future Indian Air Force (IAF) pilot and only the second Indian in space Shubhanshu Shukla was not one of those kids, born a full year later, Sharma had already spelled the trajectory of his life. Over a four-decade-long journey that would involve chance, grit, ambition and unerring talent, this boy from Lucknow would follow Sharma and become Astronaut 634, climbing aboard the International Space Station (ISS) in July last year and making history for Indian spaceflight.

"Pursuing a dream is in itself a huge accomplishment," Shukla said at the India Today Conclave in Mumbai in September. He was 17 years old when a classmate left behind an empty application for the National Defence Academy on a desk. Shukla picked it up, filled it and blasted off, not even telling his parents his plans at first. Four years later, he was commissioned into the IAF as a fighter pilot. The next big step came more than a decade later, when the Gaganyaan programme, India's first manned spaceflight mission, was in full swing and Shukla began training as an astronaut.

The year 2024 was busy. He was elevated to the rank of Group Captain and recruited by Axiom-4, a NASA-supported private astronaut mission, to represent one of only four nations headed to the ISS. It was historic for multiple reasons, marking as it did a return to space after more than 40 years for India, Poland and Hungary, and with Shukla in the cockpit of the space capsule. "There's a saying in the spaceflight community," he said.

How He Made it to Space

- **A seasoned Indian Air Force test pilot, Shukla has 2,000 hours of flight experience**
- **His spaceflight training began in 2020 when India's first manned spaceflight programme, Gaganyaan, took off in full swing**
- **The trip that made him the first Indian on the International Space Station was a multinational effort**

"You are ready for a spaceflight mission when you finish one." In June 2025, he was strapped into a rocket designed by SpaceX and zoomed off to a dizzying 28,500 km/h during which, he said, "all anticipation goes right out of the window".

Shukla's first glimpse of Earth from orbit was overwhelming. "My first thought was that of oneness with the Earth. There